

The main difference between these two commands is the **scope** of what they display. Think of `docker ps` as a "live status" view and `docker ps -a` as a "history and status" view.

1. `docker ps` (Running Only)

This command only lists containers that are **currently active** and running.

- If a container has finished its task (Exited) or was stopped manually, it will **not** appear here.
- **Best for:** Seeing what is currently consuming resources on your system right now.

2. `docker ps -a` (All Containers)

The `-a` stands for "**All**". This lists every container that exists on your host's disk, regardless of its state.

- It includes containers that are **Running**, **Exited** (stopped), **Created** (but never started), or **Paused**.
- **Best for:** Finding old containers to restart them, checking why a container crashed (looking at the "Status" column), or cleaning up unused containers.

Comparison Table

Feature	<code>docker ps</code>	<code>docker ps -a</code>
Running Containers	Yes	Yes
Stopped/Exited Containers	No	Yes
Created (but not started)	No	Yes
Output Length	Usually shorter	Can be very long
Primary Use	Monitoring active tasks	Debugging and management

Pro Tip:

If you find that `docker ps -a` shows way too many old containers and you want to clean them up, you can run:

```
docker container prune
```

This will delete all stopped containers at once to save disk space.

Do you currently have many "Exited" containers showing up when you run the `-a` command?